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## The local and the global: the multiple visual worlds of ivory carvers in early modern Sri Lanka

*Sujatha Arundathi Meegama*

In contrast to South Asian ivory carvers, European ivory carvers in the late medieval and early modern period are generally not anonymous – their identities are known by their precise locations and names: for example, we know that in the fourteenth century, the Embriachi workshop in Venice made polygonal ivory caskets as marriage gifts; while in the 1600s, Nikolaus Pfaff created beautiful ivory statuettes for Emperor Rudolf II.<sup>1</sup> But while contemporary Sri Lankan ivory carvers produced objects of comparable quality, most notably for the Portuguese court, we struggle to identify where exactly these were created, by whom and for whom; and we know almost nothing about how they functioned in their first context in Sri Lanka.<sup>2</sup>

Sixteenth-century Sri Lankan ivory carvers created the now-famous ivory caskets scattered in public and private collections throughout the world, as well as a number of fans and combs, and also religious representations, including images of the Virgin Mary and Jesus.<sup>3</sup> These artists' visual world was destroyed by Portuguese plundering missions<sup>4</sup> and the subsequent occupation of the kingdom of Kōtṭe and its environs.<sup>5</sup> In fact, not much sixteenth-century art survives today in Sri Lanka itself. Writing the history of the country's art between the 1400s and the 1700s is challenging because much of what is left consists of ruins, scattered pillars, doorways and basement mouldings, or monuments that underwent later reconstruction. Yet the visual world of sixteenth-century Sri Lanka partially survives precisely because artefacts from this complex encounter were scattered across the globe as a consequence of the Portuguese presence in the region. Thus, even if we cannot retrieve the names of the carvers or their workshops,<sup>6</sup> some aspects of their identities and their visual worlds have withstood the passage of time. The traces these carvers left behind on the thirteen surviving ivory caskets<sup>7</sup> currently datable to the sixteenth century may help us not only retrieve some aspects of the art of ivory carving and architecture in Sri Lanka, but also reveal a deeply connected global visual world in the early modern period.<sup>8</sup>

Several of the caskets can be categorized as diplomatic gifts or exotic luxury goods, created with the Lisbon court or European patrons in mind.<sup>9</sup> The Sri Lankan ivory caskets are modelled on the form of sixteenth-century European leather caskets adorned with metal handles.<sup>10</sup> But, in contrast to those, they are covered with floral designs, animal motifs and human figures. Some caskets illustrate historical scenes, while others show local ideals of kingship. Depictions of Sri Lankan rulers, seated on thrones at court like Bōdhisattvas, are placed opposite portrayals of kings riding elephants to battle. The niches of some caskets feature scenes from the Rāmāyaṇa, a narrative that has received little attention in Sri Lanka, but that became popular in the sixteenth century.<sup>11</sup> Others depict Christian imagery, with stories from the Life of the Virgin and the Life of Christ. A few caskets depict elaborate fauna and flora, with hardly any negative space left on the surfaces.

Previous scholarship has emphasized the subject matter – historical, mythological, Christian – of these ivory caskets, and linked it to the caskets' specific functions as diplomatic gifts,<sup>12</sup> luxury curiosities<sup>13</sup> or export art.<sup>14</sup> Yet while we have learned much about the place of such objects in Renaissance curiosity collections<sup>15</sup> as well as about their famous collectors,<sup>16</sup> these kinds of frameworks, despite their merits, have limited our understanding of the makers of these objects and their multiple visual worlds.

That European prints were used by the carvers is no secret: the presence of European motifs on the caskets has received attention for more than eighty years now.<sup>17</sup> Most scholars, however, have focused on the 'European-ness' of these complex objects of encounter – or to put it more mildly, the European aspects that were introduced and hence brought about change in what has been perceived as the comparatively static art worlds of South Asia. Thus the Portuguese art historian Nuno Vassallo e Silva has noted that 'it is relatively easy to identify European prints as the *sources* used for the decorative motifs on Sinhalese ivory during this period'.<sup>18</sup> More recently, Annemarie Jordan Gschwend's extensive exhibition catalogue on ivories from Ceylon has also highlighted, very convincingly, the use of European prints in Sri Lankan ivories.<sup>19</sup> However, such an emphasis implies that Sri Lankan artists copied European models with assiduity but little originality, as passive subjects of a new, global market growing beyond their reach. In other words, these objects are ascribed a derivative nature even when their genesis is seen as part of an encounter.

When non-European aspects of the caskets are commented on, the picture tends to be schematic. Amin Jaffer and Melanie Anne Schwabe, the authors of the most frequently cited article on the subject, acknowledge the importance of local motifs and emphasize the intertwinement of the *two* striking visual traditions in these caskets. But they also argue that the caskets can be 'differentiated according to the degree of European influence found in their decoration'.<sup>20</sup> Implicit in the latter statement is a problematic preconception: that all South Asian art looks similar, so that only by studying the degree of European influence can one differentiate between artworks, not by examining the South Asian characteristics at play.<sup>21</sup>

In reality, however, the ivory caskets have much more to tell us if we are willing to study the hybrid logic of their ornamentation – the use and the placement of South Asian motifs, and the way European motifs have been appropriated rather than simply ‘copied’ to become a part of the island’s visual world. Although the makers of these caskets put much effort into carving traditional South Asian motifs, their visual responses to European prints indicate that they were also quite clearly part of a larger connected world. I therefore propose that we situate these ivory caskets primarily within the context of the Sri Lankan and South Asian art worlds where they materialized in the first place. I suggest that the local motifs themselves, and their location on the caskets, illustrate the similarities between various local artistic mediums, including ivory carving and temple architecture. This chapter will show, through a close visual analysis of a group of motifs on the caskets, that these can be observed in connection with significant features on temples. I shall then place the ivory caskets back in the wider visual traditions of the early modern world, but maintain an emphasis on the agency of Sri Lankan artists, arguing that it is at least as important as the agency usually ascribed to the European models that circulated throughout the continents.

Read in such a light, the materials show that the Sri Lankan ivory carvers were as inventive and innovative as painters in the Mughal Empire and Japan, ivory carvers in Africa and the Philippines, and other artists from China to Latin America, in appropriating and transforming European motifs and forms. The visual complexity of these ivory caskets needs to be located in the visual traditions of a connected early modern world, in which sometimes the same European print was appropriated in different ways by artists in the Americas, Africa and Asia. The emphasis on the act of appropriation and transformation – something that might be termed ‘visual response’<sup>22</sup> – not only helps in retrieving traces of the historical identities of the carvers and their visual surroundings, but also brings attention to the importance of local agency in the transfer of artistic knowledge across early modern art worlds.

## Revisiting the ‘local’: ivory caskets and temple architecture

Although the comparison of ivory caskets and temple architecture may seem peculiar, scholars have adopted a similar framework, bridging genres and materials, to understand the origins of a particular group of ivories produced during Portugal’s encounter with various African kingdoms.<sup>23</sup> In the early 1460s, when the Portuguese started to interact with what is now called Sierra Leone, ivory objects such as saltcellars, spoons, forks, knife handles, hunting horns and pyxes began to be imported to Portugal.<sup>24</sup> A term coined by William Fagg, ‘Afro-Portuguese’ ivories,<sup>25</sup> refers to ivories from first Sierra Leone, then Benin,<sup>26</sup> and lastly the Kingdom of Kongo. Scholars propose that such ivories were carved as ‘gifts for the patrons of the Portuguese voyages’,<sup>27</sup> and were also ‘made for sale to Portuguese elites, missionaries, and traders’.<sup>28</sup> Although their origins were

generally forgotten in *Kunstkammern* and in other Western collections, Afro-Portuguese ivories clearly contain both African and Renaissance components.<sup>29</sup> Recent scholarship suggests that the ivories from Sierra Leone may be related to the local carving tradition of small stone figures (*nomoli*).<sup>30</sup> William Fagg and Ezio Bassani have pointed out the similarities in the treatment of the faces, the scarification marks on the upper bodies, and the objects or themes depicted on the local stone figures to those on the exported ivories.<sup>31</sup> Similarly, the geometric patterns that adorn Kongo 'oliphants' (carved elephant tusks) reflect the designs on Kongo textiles.<sup>32</sup> In other words, artists working in a particular medium can be inspired by designs common in other mediums. This may help us to think about artistic practice, repositories of artistic knowledge and the ways in which ideas cross material and visual boundaries, not only in Africa but also in Sri Lanka from stone architecture to ivory and prints to ivory.

At first glance, all thirteen ivory caskets from sixteenth-century Sri Lanka create an impression of similarity due to their material, shape and pervasive ornamentation. Although they come in different sizes, they are all formed as rectangular boxes, presenting a rectangular front and a back with arched sides and a pitched lid.<sup>33</sup> All five rectangular faces of the ivory caskets are generally divided into three panels each.<sup>34</sup> The method of construction is also shared; 'the front, back and side are dovetailed to each other and the bottom fashioned in panel-and groove construction'.<sup>35</sup> The similarities continue with the carvings, showing Sri Lankan or European mythological stories, historical events, religious narratives and figures, and motifs that include fauna and flora, as well as geometrical patterns.

Jaffer and Schwabe have argued that the 'ornament on the caskets can be related to the changing socio-political situation in Ceylon, that is to say, that those caskets worked exclusively with indigenous ornament pre-date those worked with European motifs'.<sup>36</sup> Most often, the ornamentation does indeed correspond to the socio-political context, but my intention is not to question this chronological approach. Instead, I suggest that we look at the ornamentation itself – the motifs, the figures and their placement – to locate these objects in many visual contexts. This should allow us to turn to the multiple visual traditions that these objects are in conversation with, and understand the complexity of such hybrid objects in the early modern period.

The similarities in the ornamentation extend not only to the subjects depicted but also, at a more fundamental level, to the placement of particular motifs. Their arrangement reflects, crucially, the visual organization of the sub-structures of South Asian temples. Initially made with a flat bottom surface,<sup>37</sup> the ivory caskets are generally adorned with a row of lotus petals on all four sides at the very bottom; this can be seen in the Rāmāyaṇa casket in the Kunsthistorisches Museum in Vienna (Figure 6.1) and the second ivory casket in the same collection. The so-called Robinson casket at the Victoria and Albert Museum has two rows of lotus petals facing each other (Figure 6.2). The most elaborate petals are found on



**Fig. 6.1** 'Rāmāyaṇa casket', front panel, Sri Lanka, mid-sixteenth century, KHM-Museumsverband, Wien, Inventory no. KK 4743.



**Fig. 6.2** 'Robinson casket', Sri Lanka, probably Kōṭṭe, mid-sixteenth century, © Victoria and Albert Museum, London, Inventory no. IS.41-1980.





**Fig. 6.3** 'Coronation casket', Kōttē, c.1541, Schatzkammer der Residenz, Munich, Inventory no. 1241.

the bottom of the so-called coronation casket at the Residenzmuseum in Munich (Figure 6.3). Caskets that do not have the row of lotus petals instead have a less elaborate arrangement, again resembling the basement mouldings of some South Asian temples: the ivory casket at the Boston Museum of Fine Arts thus sits on a plinth, which in turn supports the S-shaped *cyma recta* topped by a small fillet (Figure 6.4); a similar plinth, further ornamented with gold and rubies, can be seen in a casket kept in an undisclosed private collection.<sup>38</sup> Such features ornamenting basements, especially lotus petals, are often found in Sri Lankan temple architecture from the Anurādhapura period (c. 250 BCE–982 CE) onwards.<sup>39</sup>

This is where the issue of whether or not a distinct local style exists comes into the picture. Senake Bandaranayake's extensive studies on the basement mouldings of temples in Anurādhapura indicate a particular pattern of mouldings that consist of rectilinear and curvilinear mouldings.<sup>40</sup> The curvilinear mouldings include the plain S-shaped *cyma recta*, which at times is adorned by lotus petals – as seen above, some of the ivory caskets follow curvilinear mouldings that have lotus petals carved on them. Much closer in time to the ivory caskets, we have the Bārāṇḍi Kōvil of Sitāvaka (Figure 6.5), a rare example of a sixteenth-century temple that has not been completely rebuilt since its destruction at the hands of the Portuguese. The basement moulding of this Hindu temple is quite complex, given that it sits on a particularly large plinth on which devotees may have circumambulated. The basement moulding of the temple proper consists of a plinth,



**Fig. 6.4** Casket, front panel, Sri Lanka, mid- to late sixteenth century, Photograph © 2017 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, Bequest of William A. Coolidge, Accession no. 1993.29.



**Fig. 6.5** Basement moulding, Bārāṇḍi Kōvil, Sītāvaka, mid-sixteenth century, author's photograph.



two fillets, a *cyma recta* adorned with lotus petals, followed by a fillet-dado-fillet, then a carved rectilinear torus (*tripaṭṭa kumuda*), with again the standard fillet-dado-fillet, followed by a *cyma recta* with elaborate lotus petals, and finally ending with the cornice. Like the earlier Sri Lankan temple mouldings and the Sri Lankan ivory caskets, the Bārāṇḍi Kōvil has the S-curved *cyma recta* adorned with lotus petals. But, the latter also includes the moulding *tripaṭṭa kumuda*, which is a feature associated with South Indian temples built in the subcontinent.<sup>41</sup> The presence of the architectural feature, the *tripaṭṭa kumuda*, indicates that this temple was built by a South Indian rather than a local workshop – as were in fact a number of earlier, Hindu and Buddhist temples in Anurādhapura, Polonnaruwa, Yāpahuva, Gampola and Kandy.

But what exactly do we mean by ‘South Indian’ in a Sri Lankan context; on what grounds can we distinguish ‘South Indian’ or ‘Sri Lankan’? In general, specific motifs or features and their combinations are taken as strong indicators of whether a monument was built by a local or a South Indian workshop. Thus, for example, in describing a group of ivory panels containing numerous representations of the dancing Śiva, Ananda Coomaraswamy identifies a motif of ‘horned and bird-headed “lions”’ and notes that such a feature points to a South Indian origin.<sup>42</sup> Under such a lens, the casket in the Távora Sequeira Pinto Collection, with its filigree-like surface ornamentation and the dynamic horned and bird-headed lion motif, may well turn out to be from South India.<sup>43</sup> But apart from divulging the possible geographical association of creation, what else might such motifs or architectural features tell us of relevance to Sri Lankan and South Indian art histories? That such practitioners were born abroad? That they were trained overseas? That they followed imported models? That they migrated for work? That local and South Indian practitioners worked side-by-side?

If we entertain such questions, then what exactly does an architectural element that originated outside of Sri Lanka mean for our quest of a potentially cosmopolitan artistic culture on the island? The presence of the *tripaṭṭa kumuda* alone certainly does not mean that a building is automatically a South Indian Hindu temple. This feature, for example, can also be found on the basement mouldings of Buddhist temples (the Temple of the Tooth at Yāpahuva and the Gaḍalādeṇiya Rājamahā Vihāraya). One must underline that this architectural element appears in various types of religious structures in Sri Lanka, including Hindu kōvils, Buddhist vihāras and the hybrid devāles (temples to pan-Indic and local deities) – indicating that perhaps South Indian workshops were responsible for more than just the construction of Hindu kōvils in Sri Lanka. In other words, an architectural feature alone can hardly be associated with a particular religion or a bounded region.<sup>44</sup> Motifs and forms circulated between India and Sri Lanka, and between various religious traditions; practitioners travelled across the Palk straits, perhaps to find new patrons and work. To separate the exogenous from the endogenous thus requires more study, and yet at the same time we must remember that South Indian workshops may have worked alongside local workshops; after all, there are no exact replicas of South Indian temples in premodern Sri Lanka.

The Sri Lankan ivory caskets do not display such complicated basement mouldings as temples do, and the mouldings on the ivories do not indicate as clearly as those on temples whether South Indian workshops played a role or not; however, certain features found on the bottom layer of the caskets in London, Munich, Vienna and Boston are clearly inspired by this architectural tradition, which is seen in both Buddhist and Hindu temples.

A few of the ivory caskets also share the symbol of a lion: a lively row of lions runs along the bottom of all four sides of the so-called coronation casket in Munich (Figure 6.3), the casket that depicts certain scenes from the Rāmāyaṇa in Vienna (Figure 6.1), and the casket with more Rāmāyaṇa scenes on it at the Teaching and Research Museum of the University of Peradeniya in Sri Lanka (Figure 6.6). The motif of lions, here seemingly moving towards each other from both directions, or moving away from each other in opposite directions, is generally associated with royalty.<sup>45</sup> The ivory carver(s) of the second casket in Munich chose to use the motif only on the two side-end scenes (Figure 6.7), which are related directly to Sri Lankan kingship: these lions are more robust and are compressed together, seemingly lacking space as they stride towards the middle. The casket in Boston, too, has lions only on its two shorter sides (Figure 6.8). The fact that the lion motif is not used on all thirteen caskets seems to suggest that at least five caskets came out of possibly royal workshops – although perhaps not from the hand of the same carver, since the lotus petals mentioned above are different in each casket, and the lion motif itself appears similarly differentiated through number, placement, direction and style.

Like the lotus petals, rows of lions appear on the basement mouldings of certain medieval monuments. At Polonnaruva (1017–1215 CE), this motif is found



**Fig. 6.6** ‘Peradeniya casket’, back panel, Sri Lanka, mid-sixteenth century, The Senarat Paranavitana Teaching and Research Museum, Department of Archaeology, University of Peradeniya, author’s photograph.



Fig. 6.7 Casket, lateral panel (left), Kōtte, 1540s, Schatzkammer der Residenz, Munich, Inventory no. 1242.

on the basement mouldings of the audience halls of King Parākramabāhu I and King Niśsaṅkamalla, as well as at the Buddhist structures of Manik Vehera (*stupa*) and Hāṭadāgē (image house). From the fourteenth-century Gampola kingdom, we see lions carved in various postures on the stone basement mouldings of the entrance pavilion to Niyamgampāya Rājamahā Vihāra. At Gaḍalādeṇiya Rājamahā Vihāraya, a row of lions adorns the stone steps leading up to the temple



**Fig. 6.8** Casket, lateral panel (left), Sri Lanka, mid- to late sixteenth century, Photograph © 2017 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, Bequest of William A. Coolidge, Accession no. 1993.29.

(Figure 6.9). This motif and its location echo the *vyāla*, or mythical-lion motif, found especially on the basement mouldings of Hindu temples in South India, as well as in those built in Sri Lanka. The basement mouldings of Śiva Devale No. 1 in Polonnaruwa, an eleventh- or twelfth-century stone Hindu temple in Sri Lanka (Figure 6.10) built by a South Indian workshop, provide an excellent example of the historical visual complexity of the lion motif and its placement at the bottom





Fig. 6.9 Gaḍalādeṇiya Rājamahā Vihāraya, 1344 CE, author's photograph.



Fig. 6.10 Śiva Devāle No. 1, Polonnaruwa, eleventh or twelfth century, author's photograph.



of these ivory caskets. It is associated not only with kingship, but also with South Indian temples and workshops.

This analysis suggests that the carvers did not refrain from using motifs and structural features from temple architecture, and also reveals that at times such features were taken originally from the South Indian architectural tradition.<sup>46</sup> A number of architectural features – such as the lion motif on the basement mouldings – were introduced to the island at various moments of engagement with South Indian architectural traditions. They were then adopted by ivory carvers, whose works eventually gained a better chance of survival than the temples because they were exported to Europe. So were the ivory carvers aware of the origins of these architectural features? Or does their engagement with such elements of the architectural tradition indicate that those features were long localized? It is difficult to give a clear answer at this point.

However, it is certainly useful to remind ourselves that not all South Indian architectural features were adopted wholesale: various imported elements were appropriated, transformed or rejected by local workshops creating localized architectural formulas. The ivory carvers, in turn, chose only certain architectural features for their ivory caskets; and even then, each casket differs in its use of mouldings and the lion motif, indicating perhaps different hands or workshops. The architectural references found in the caskets clearly allude to shared visual heritages between Sri Lanka and South India. While colonial and postcolonial scholarly constructions of national boundaries and art historical canons have led to an emphasis on the separateness between Sri Lankan and Indian art, it seems necessary to reconsider the connectedness of the art histories of the region as a whole. Clearly, the local is not so local after all – it, too, is part of larger, connecting art histories.

## Reconnecting with the ‘global’: ivory caskets and European prints

The presence of European motifs on Sri Lankan ivory caskets indicates that carvers in the island turned to a visual world extending well beyond the limits of South Asia. But what exactly was the gesture underlying such an operation? Were Sri Lankans copying European motifs? Were they doing something more complex? Is there a fundamental novelty to bringing elements of European, rather than ‘just’ South Indian art, into Sri Lankan objects? In this section, I focus on the appropriation of European prints in the so-called Robinson Casket (Figure 6.2) at the Victoria and Albert Museum in London.<sup>47</sup>

Nuno Vassallo e Silva declares that the Robinson Casket ‘is a noteworthy example of the use of European prints in a Sinhalese work, demonstrating how the two influences mixed in *random fashion with no coherent discourse*’<sup>48</sup> – a statement that is indicative of how poorly understood the history of the ivory caskets remains. Asian artists, like artists in Europe – or for that matter, most artists

anywhere in the world, whether anonymous or not – had intentions behind their creations. There is rarely such a thing as a completely random artistic act. It thus makes sense to search for the rationale underlying the visual programme of the caskets.

In fact, Amin Jaffer and Melanie Schwabe have examined the Robinson Casket in great detail, bringing attention to the socio-historical context of its production.<sup>49</sup> They suggest that this is the first casket to include Christian subject matter, and so date it to 1557, the year of the conversion of King Dharmapāla. They also argue that ‘the iconography of the casket [...] develops the themes of birth and re-birth in both Christian and Sinhalese motifs’,<sup>50</sup> and therefore celebrates the birth of a Portuguese heir, Sebastian, the grandson of John III.<sup>51</sup> The concerns of the two royal houses are thus brought together in one object. To further their argument, Jaffer and Schwabe examine in detail the foreign and the local subject matter depicted. They turn first to the depiction of two events that are seminal in the Life of Christ: on the back of the casket, the left niche features an image of Mary and Joseph, while the right panel shows them resting during their escape to Egypt (Figure 6.11); Vassallo e Silva argues that these two scenes show the Visitation and the Nativity.<sup>52</sup> On the right end of the casket, the genealogy of Christ is depicted through the Tree of Jesse, a common representation of the ancestors of Christ (Figure 6.12); this imagery has been traced to a Book of Hours



**Fig. 6.11** ‘Robinson casket’, back panel, Sri Lanka, probably Kōṭṭe, mid-sixteenth century, © Victoria and Albert Museum, London, Inventory no. IS.41–1980.



**Fig. 6.12** Tree of Jesse on the 'Robinson casket', lateral panel (right), Sri Lanka, probably Kōtṭe, mid-sixteenth century, © Victoria and Albert Museum, London, Inventory no. IS.41–1980.

printed by Thielman Kerver as early as 1499 (Figure 6.13), and reprinted repeatedly at least until 1546.<sup>53</sup> Apart from these depictions, Jaffer and Schwabe point to the reproduction of a print by Albrecht Dürer from 1514 on the front of the casket, which appears twice, in the right and left niches (Figure 6.2). They also point to two other scenes on the uppermost portion of the lid of this casket that were inspired by European prints.<sup>54</sup>

After this exhaustive account of the presence of European prints, Jaffer and Schwabe turn their attention to the local motifs on the Robinson Casket that are associated with birth and rebirth or creation,<sup>55</sup> especially the 'cord of life' that





**Fig. 6.13** Tree of Jesse from the Book of Hours of Thielmann Kerver, Paris, c. 1507, Collection Paulus Swaen Auctions.



**Fig. 6.14** *Kalpavrksha/Kalpalata* (auspicious vines) on the ‘Robinson casket’, lateral panel (left), Sri Lanka, probably Kōṭṭe, mid-sixteenth century, © Victoria and Albert Museum, London, Inventory no. IS.41–1980.

emerges out of the tails of the half-man, half-bird creatures (Figure 6.11) as well as from the mouths of two *makara*-headed lions on the left end (Figure 6.14). Based on the unusual combination of the *makara* and the lion, they suggest that ‘here the artist may have sought to emphasize the role of kingship (represented by the lion) in creation, as represented by the *makara* and cord of life’.<sup>56</sup> Jaffer and



Schwabe conclude that the combination of these various motifs, both local and foreign, ‘join to convey the message of creation, rebirth and renewal of life in the Christian faith and tradition’.<sup>57</sup>

Despite all this perspicacious reasoning, there is no concrete visual or textual evidence that this casket was sent as a gift for John III from Kōtte to Lisbon in 1557. At most, we may say that it was likely made after the arrival of the Franciscans at King Bhuvanekabāhu’s court in 1543; for the Franciscans surely brought gifts and teaching materials, including European prints, to present to Bhuvanekabāhu.<sup>58</sup> While the casket has been interpreted as a diplomatic gift, it could be pointed out that a comparable display of scenes from the Life of the Virgin appears in ‘Afro-Portuguese’ pyxes from Sierra Leone, produced for liturgical purposes.<sup>59</sup> The casket and the pyxes share similar European print sources,<sup>60</sup> but could they also share similar patrons? In other words, was this casket produced for a missionary, or perhaps as a gift to a church official in Lisbon?

Rather than venturing any further into who the patrons of such objects may have been and what functions the caskets may have been meant to perform, I suggest that we shift our attention to the act of appropriation of European prints by Sri Lankan ivory carvers, and engage with the idea of recovering the traces of an anonymous subject in an early colonial context in Asia. This approach should allow us to highlight the connected nature of the ivory carvers’ visual world, and the active agency performed by them as they appropriated foreign motifs. ‘Appropriation’ as a process has been explored by the art historian Robert Nelson with reference to the discipline of art history;<sup>61</sup> in particular, Nelson notes the inadequacy of terms such as ‘borrowings’ and ‘influence’, which have been used by scholars in the discipline when referring to artworks adopting ‘pre-existing elements’.<sup>62</sup> His insightful observations bring attention not only to the agency of ‘the maker or receiver’,<sup>63</sup> but also to the production of meaning. Each time a sign is appropriated, the agent builds on the meaning of the previous sign to generate a new significance.<sup>64</sup>

With this theoretical framework in mind, let us return to the Robinson Casket, shifting our attention to the ways in which the agent – the Sri Lankan ivory carver – appropriated a European print.<sup>65</sup> As we have seen, in the large panel on the left end of the casket, the carver has carved the Tree of Jesse, which follows a pre-existing model from a European print (Figure 6.13). Looking back through a long history in the West,<sup>66</sup> one can see that this motif was appropriated not only by Sri Lankan, but also by South Indian, African and Latin American artists around the same period. Unlike the versions in Sierra Leone,<sup>67</sup> Colonial Mexico,<sup>68</sup> or South India,<sup>69</sup> the version by the Sri Lankan ivory carver faithfully reproduces the subject matter and the composition of the print – the tree, the framing pillars, the floral motifs that create a bower at the top, the number of figures and their location, the hand gestures and body postures of all the figures, their head-dresses and clothing, and the cartouches.

There are, of course, some subtle differences between the print and the ivory version,<sup>70</sup> the most obvious being the twelve empty cartouches and the addition of two 'floating flowers' – the latter a distinct mark of Sri Lankan ivory carvers and painters.<sup>71</sup> Perhaps it was not important for the carver to copy faithfully the writing on the twelve cartouches: the initial patron of the casket may have felt that the writing did not matter as much as the image. In fact, the cartouches do not even appear in all European versions of the Tree of Jesse,<sup>72</sup> indicating that the image can function without the textual notation providing the names of the twelve figures. Scholars who have examined this casket so far have not only ignored these slight changes the carver made; more importantly, they have not paid adequate attention to the carver's visual response to the Tree of Jesse in a different panel on the same casket.<sup>73</sup> Based on the representation of the Tree of Jesse along with other events from the Life of Christ, scholars have argued that the casket represents Dharmapāla's conversion – the rupture between Buddhist and Christian beliefs. However, the visual response to the Tree of Jesse in another niche on the same casket reveals a more complex relationship between Western colonial culture and a soon-to-be Asian colony. Rather than being merely a straightforward narrative of rupture, the visual response of the ivory carver also indicates a narrative of recognition, familiarity and continuity. The imagery is about not only Western, but also South Asian notions of kingship, creation, auspiciousness and prosperity. This act of appropriation, I suggest, responds both to the global visual world and to the local South Asian context.<sup>74</sup>

How is the ivory carver's visual response a narrative about kingship, creation, auspiciousness and prosperity? On the large panel forming the opposite end of the casket (Figure 6.14), two vines emerge out of the mouth of two *makara*-headed lions, placed on either side at the bottom of the panel. Like Jesse, the ancestor of Christ, the lion is the ancestor of Sri Lankan kings: Vijaya, the first king of the island, is believed to have descended from the union of a lion and a human princess.<sup>75</sup> Apart from its royal connotations, the lion is also a motif associated with the Buddha, one of whose epithets is 'Shakya Simha'.<sup>76</sup> The mythical *makara*, associated with water and consisting of an elephant's head and a lion's body, brings together two important and auspicious animals associated with kingship.<sup>77</sup>

As for the branches of this 'tree', the carver has placed animals on them instead of kings, and some of these carry strong auspicious associations. Encircled within beaded vines, some are placed frontally, while most others are in profile: at the very centre, in the first circle from the bottom, is a frontally seated lion; above him is a peacock displaying his fan; further above is a lion in profile; on top of that is a deer; next comes what is perhaps a lamb; and finally, at the very top, is a frontally positioned bird. This vertical sequence of animals functions visually in correspondence with the strong central trunk of the Tree of Jesse. Moving downwards from left to right, more vines with various creatures emerge out of this central trunk-like motif: the carver has placed a pair of similar birds or animals extending

across horizontally; some are encircled by the beaded vines, while others seem to roam the 'tree' free of any vines, in-between the stems, leaves and flowers.

As can be seen, there is a striking similarity between the compositions of the Tree of Jesse and the ivory carver's visual response: the bottom row of three leonine creatures functions as the basis of this tree, very much like Jesse himself in the European tradition; the central row of animals mimics the latter's strong vertical branch; the different levels of animals encircled by vines correspond to the various branches in which figures sit on the Tree of Jesse; and at the pinnacle of this 'tree' a bird is placed in a circle that corresponds to the final figures in the Tree of Jesse: Mary with the infant Jesus, placed within a circle of sacred light.

The ivory carver could have chosen to depict various kings from the local chronicles,<sup>78</sup> but chose instead to use the motif of a creeper encircling animals, which are traditionally found on pillars and doorways of South Asian monuments as an auspicious motif. The *kalpavrksa* or 'wishing tree' motif, and the *kalpalata* or 'wishing creeper motif', are seen on pillars in Anurādhapura as early as the first century CE.<sup>79</sup> This, it may be noted, is not exclusively a Sri Lankan visual resource: auspicious animals emerging out of the wishing tree or creeper are common across South Asia. The *Jātakas* have the Buddha being born in previous lives as an animal (such as a hare, elephant, monkey, etc.), while the *vāhanas*, or vehicles, of Hindu deities and *Bōdhisattvas* are equally held to be animals (such as a bull, lion, tiger, peacock, mouse, elephant, etc.). All this reinforces the impression that the local vine-with-animals is placed in dialogue with the Tree of Jesse, not only in its formal composition, but also in its iconography.

In fact, the vine-with-animals motif populates nearly every remaining niche of this ivory casket,<sup>80</sup> even one of the niches that depicts scenes from the Life of the Virgin. Thus, on the back of the body of the casket (Figure 6.11), in the central niche, two vines emerge out of the tails of half-human half-bird creatures called *kinnaras*. Placed in-between these mythical creatures is a peacock, with animals encircled by beaded creepers, and animals outside and in-between the beaded vines. Adjacent to this central niche, Mary, cradling the baby Jesus, sits under a tree populated by birds and monkeys, while Joseph looks on. A deer standing on its hind legs looks at the baby, while a parrot, just above Mary's right shoulder, peers down. Unlike in typical vines-with-animals seen in these caskets, the animals are not placed within circular vines; but the tree is similar to the vines in that it has beaded branches. It is clearly visually connected to the theme of the wishing creeper, while also dialoguing with the Christian elements that it embraces.<sup>81</sup>

Apart from these two scenes on the reverse side of the casket, the lid has various niches carrying the same motif: of a vine populated by auspicious animals. On the reverse side of the pitched lid (Figure 6.11), all three niches have animals contained within five circular beaded vines. The carver placed other animals in-between these vines and around the edges of the niches. Initially, although the niches may seem similar, the combination of animals and the directions in which they look are different. The centre niche stands out, as pairs of

animals are carved inside the circular vines except for the centre one; however, the overall composition of the three niches is the same. On the front of the pitched lid (Figure 6.2), the carver has again placed three niches, filled with similar vines and animals. The centre niche follows the same configuration of encircled vines as all three niches on the back: animals are placed within the vines as well as in-between vines and along the edges of the niches. The niches on either side take on a different composition from the centre niche as well as from the niches on the reverse side of the casket. Animals are still encircled within beaded vines, but the configuration of the circles differs.

This close – and deliberately long and detailed – visual analysis of the niches may in itself be sufficient to suggest that *randomness* is not a term appropriate to the labour of the carver(s) responsible for this casket. There was certainly some degree of freedom in the application of motifs: the carver could depict the wish-fulfilling creeper in many different ways, using different combinations of animals and circles, and placing them differently to create a variety of compositions. Exact symmetry was not a concern; and perhaps the differences in the niches also indicate that more than one carver was involved. But, more importantly, the composition and iconography of the wish-fulfilling tree opposite the Tree of Jesse on the side panel is not replicated elsewhere on this ivory casket. In fact, the visual response, through a variety of wish-fulfilling vines containing animals instead of men, indicates a complex response to the Tree of Jesse by the anonymous ivory carver. He – assuming that carvers were mostly men – understood it and engaged with it within a vibrant visual tradition of depicting auspicious vines of fertility that goes back very far in South Asian art history.

Ananda Coomaraswamy has brought attention to an old Indian parallel to the Tree of Jesse: the birth of Brahma. In one of the earliest stone temples in Deogarh, dating from the Gupta period (c.320–647 CE), Brahma is depicted seated on a lotus that emerges from a reclining Viṣṇu.<sup>82</sup> Citing various literary sources, Coomaraswamy connects the image of the ‘tree rooted in the navel’ to an old ‘iconography of water cosmology’.<sup>83</sup> He notes that this iconography typically consists of a stem of a lotus framing animals or human beings, and emerges from a pot or the mouth of the mythical-water creature, the *makara*, or a dwarf *yakṣa*, a vegetation spirit.<sup>84</sup> And indeed, our casket depicts vines emerging out of the mouths of two *makara*-headed lions and framing multiple animals with their stems. Rather than using a *makara* or a *yakṣa*, the ivory carver chose a *makara*-headed lion: Jesse is thus echoed by one animal aspect associated with water, and by another associated with the Sri Lankan royal lineage. What was initially assumed to be a ‘randomness’ in the inclusion of a European print along with local motifs, thus gives way to a remarkably rich and coherent discourse about fertility, auspiciousness and a genealogy tracing the ancestry of the Sri Lankan kings to a lion.

Crucially, too, the Robinson casket does not stand alone in this regard. This type of vine replete with birds and animals also appears in the two caskets in Munich, the two caskets in Vienna, the caskets in Boston, Paris and Peradeniya,





**Fig. 6.15** Casket, lid, Sri Lanka, mid- to late sixteenth century, Photograph © 2017 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, Bequest of William A. Coolidge, Accession no. 1993.29.

and a casket in a European private collection. In the last, as well as in one of the caskets in Vienna, this motif dominates every single panel.<sup>85</sup> The carver of the casket in Boston, too, chose to use the motif on three faces of the lid (Figure 6.15) and on the main body (Figure 6.4 and Figure 6.16); however, in this case, the carver also decided not to use it in the large side niches at each end of the casket (Figure 6.8). In the other caskets, the motif is mostly visible on the lid: in the ‘coronation casket’ it appears on the topmost section of the lid (Figure 6.17); in the second casket in Munich the vine is also seen on the topmost portion of the lid; and similarly in the ‘Rāmāyaṇa casket’ in Vienna and in the Peradeniya casket the motif is seen only in the uppermost portion of the lid. Using this motif to adorn the upper portions of caskets seems to have become a standard manner of ornamenting ivory caskets: by the fourteenth century, if not earlier, such auspicious vines with animal and human figures entwined within creepers appear on stone doorways of medieval temples (Figure 6.18); and indeed, the choice of ornamenting a lid with an auspicious motif does not seem surprising, as its function corresponds to that of a doorway.

If the Robinson casket stands out, along with the casket in Vienna, for the way in which the vine motif dominates the side panels, it is also important to point out that the caskets present substantial differences between them. In the Robinson casket, the wish-fulfilling tree composition clearly corresponds to that of the Tree of Jesse. In the large side panels of the Vienna casket, the Tree of Jesse as such is



**Fig. 6.16** Casket, back panel, Sri Lanka, mid- to late sixteenth century, Photograph © 2017 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, Bequest of William A. Coolidge, Accession no. 1993.29.



**Fig. 6.17** 'Coronation casket', lid, Kōtō, c.1541, Schatzkammer der Residenz, Munich, Inventory no. 1241.

absent: the panels are completely ornamented with vines full of birds and animals, the latter encompassed by six circles of vines; and in-between the vines and at their edges are birds. The composition is similar to that of the vines full of animals and birds that are found on the lids of most of these caskets: rather than from an



**Fig. 6.18** Galapatha Rājamahā Vihāra, Bentota, fourteenth or fifteenth century, author's photograph.

animal, the vine emerges from a potted plant in the centre – perhaps a pot of plenty, yet another local motif of fertility. Various types of animals are placed within circular vines as well as outside the vines. The panel at the left end consistently depicts animals being attacked at every level; in fact, this casket is full of animals attacking one another – a motif and an aesthetic that are not seen in the Robinson casket. The composition and iconography of these two side panels in the second casket in

Vienna show that although sixteenth-century ivory caskets may seem to contain similar motifs, each casket is different, leaving much work for art historians willing to engage with and learn from such iconographic programmes. More importantly, none of the other caskets that contain various versions of the wish-fulfilling tree or vine replicate the tree-like vine found on the Robinson Casket.

The Tree of Jesse itself travelled around the world as a motif during the sixteenth century. In each instance, it was appropriated differently by artists in Sierra Leone, Mexico, South India<sup>86</sup> and Sri Lanka. In Sierra Leone – as Sri Lanka before the end of the sixteenth century, a region outside of Portugal's growing empire – the Tree of Jesse was deployed to adorn the body of an ivory pyx, a container used for carrying the Eucharist.<sup>87</sup> The three extant pyxes are cylindrical in shape, presenting a form similar to that of the European liturgical vessels used in this period. Two have lids and are supported by small figures of four lions.<sup>88</sup> As in the Sri Lankan ivories, the surfaces of these pyxes are completely covered in carvings. The three pyxes are adorned with scenes from the Life of the Virgin and the Passion of Christ, again modelled after illustrations in printed European Books of Hours.<sup>89</sup> In one pyx, the Tree of Jesse is combined with numerous other scenes inspired by various illustrations from a Book of Hours printed by Philippe Pigouchet, namely the Annunciation, the Visitation, the Birth of Jesus, the Annunciation to the Shepherds and the Adoration of the Magi.<sup>90</sup> The African carver has chosen six scenes out of the twenty-one coloured illustrations about the Life of the Virgin and the Life of Christ given by Pigouchet, if indeed he saw the Book of Hours published in 1498.<sup>91</sup> Each scene is separated by a pillar-like form with a twisted ribbed effect and a knob in the middle. The Tree of Jesse is clearly the central image on the body of the pyx because, as with most ivories made in Sierra Leone, the lid or the uppermost portion of this container includes a three-dimensional figure as well: the figure of Mary cradling the baby Jesus, facing in the same direction as the Tree of Jesse. Jesse lies at the bottom of the niche with the tree emerging out of his navel. His right arm is placed by his side, while he raises his left to his face.<sup>92</sup>

The configuration of figures is different from the European print: rather than twelve kings, the carver chose to depict seven; and rather than six branches, the carver chose to depict four. The goal seems to have been not to render faithfully each figure but to depict the gist of the story. In the centre, Mary holds the baby Jesus as she emerges out of a halo of flames. The ultimate flowering of the tree in the form of Mary and Jesus is replicated beyond the two-dimensional surface of the pyx: in a sensitive portrayal, Mary emerges carrying Jesus. Mary is portrayed in a more humble manner, without a crown but wearing a cross at her neck – she is covered from head to toe in cloth that has a distinct pattern of a series of dots within lines,<sup>93</sup> a pattern seen again and again on these Afro-Portuguese ivories to depict the clothing of Western figures. The replication of the Virgin Mary with her son in a two-dimensional as well as a three-dimensional form in the same object indicates not only the importance of this figure for the Catholic Church, but also the carver's ingenuity.<sup>94</sup>



In colonial Mexico, the Tree of Jesse was used multiple times by different artists, possibly for different reasons; and unlike in the African and South Asian cases, the subject's use in Mexico has been studied extensively. Recently, Angelica J. Afanador-Pujol has noted that the motif first appears in an open-air chapel in Central Mexico.<sup>95</sup> Around 1540, local artists adorned two bishop's mitres with this motif,<sup>96</sup> and between 1539 and 1541 it was also deployed in a manuscript now called the 'Relación de Michoacán', which records the customs in the state of Michoacán, Mexico. Although the manuscript was commissioned by the Spanish viceroy of Mexico, the text and the accompanying illustrations represent the indigenous voices of the local nobility as well as the native artists.<sup>97</sup> One of the anonymous artists of this project appropriated the motif of the Tree of Jesse and replaced the lineage of Christ with that of the Uanacaze family, who were ruling this region when the Spanish arrived.<sup>98</sup> Afanador-Pujol argues that the purpose of this 'visual mimicry [...] was to help the Uanacaze overcome the claims of competing indigenous pretenders, [...] as well as to challenge contending claims by Spanish colonizers'.<sup>99</sup>

As with the Tree of Jesse, the Uanacaze family tree also begins with a reclining figure, this one being named Thicatame. His eighteen descendants occupy the branches that spread across a whole page. As with the print, they hold cartouches containing their names,<sup>100</sup> but their clothing, accoutrements and posture differ, and they sit on little stools that perch on the branches; many are also depicted with wounds. At the very top of the Uanacaze family tree are three figures dressed in white baptismal tunics: Zinzicha Tangaxuan is in the centre, with his two sons, Don Francisco and Don Antonio, on either side.<sup>101</sup> If the artist had followed the Tree of Jesse more passively, the two sons would have been placed in the centre as the final descendants of this family tree. However, Afanador-Pujol argues that Tangaxuan is placed at the centre because his death at the hands of the Spanish was embroiled in debate, and also affected the political and economic inheritance of his sons.<sup>102</sup> On the grounds of these many alterations, Afanador-Pujol suggests that the visual mimicry was not motivated by European interests; instead, it was a unique response to the local colonial situation: 'a tree that reveals a more complex relationship between colonizers and colonized'.<sup>103</sup>

What can we learn from Afanador-Pujol's careful study of the use of the Tree of Jesse in colonial Mexico? This use of the tree is best understood not as a passive act of rendering (in the sense of simply copying an alien original), but as an active appropriation that 'builds on a previous meaning of a sign to create yet a new sign'.<sup>104</sup> Using a motif familiar to a European audience and transforming it, the anonymous artist depicted a local genealogy and a complex political history. The choice, and the development of a motif that the local audience could relate to, also reflected indigenous beliefs about trees, especially oaks.<sup>105</sup> Drawing attention to the actions of this anonymous painter, Afanador-Pujol shows how he responded to a completely different visual tradition, and effectively communicated with *multiple* audiences. Likewise, the Sri Lankan ivory carver chose, as a response – and

indeed, as an element in a proper dialogue – a motif he was familiar with, and one that his local audience would immediately recognize: his response to the Tree of Jesse builds on an old South Asian motif of the wish-fulfilling tree or creeper. His choices of location, composition and iconography further cement the notion that he construed, consciously and intentionally, a visual response well beyond the randomness suggested by other art historians.

Examining the use of the same European print across three vastly different visual traditions and colonial contexts highlights the possibilities of appropriation in the early modern world, at a moment when Sri Lanka was connecting with distant realities through the Portuguese. At times, the artists' (and certainly their patrons') choices responded to Western visual traditions and complex political histories, but above all they were anchored in local or regional visual traditions and belief systems. These visual responses are not passive copies, but active appropriations in which colonized artists – or, in the case of mid-sixteenth-century Sri Lanka, ivory carvers producing objects for a diplomatic exchange in which Europeans were slowly gaining the upper hand over Sri Lankans – left their traces. Each time the Tree of Jesse was appropriated, it was reborn with a new meaning. Whatever the exact processes by which caskets were produced in Sri Lankan workshops, the approach I propose also throws light on the complex visual worlds, beliefs and identities of non-elite subjects, who are often overshadowed by the voices of monarchs, ministers, missionaries and merchants in the written records of the early colonial encounters.<sup>106</sup>

## Conclusion

The two contrasting but intertwined narratives in this essay suggest that these complex objects of encounter must be situated simultaneously within both local and global visual traditions. Even if we cannot retrieve the names of the carvers or workshops that produced these objects, we can, using visual analysis, uncover the agencies and art worlds that inform them. This chapter illustrates how their makers were engaged in dialogue not just with European prints but also with South Asian architecture. Both these art worlds and the various agencies in them are equally important in the process of their creation.

What this analysis then suggests is that it may be worthwhile for art historians to take up the challenge posed by Claire Farago: to write art histories from many points of view, or from many sides of an encounter. As Farago suggests, this intervention is about replacing the 'binary model of centre and periphery implied in constructs that privilege European civilization'<sup>107</sup> with a more genuinely 'dialogical model'<sup>108</sup> – one in which the voices of the local artists from the peripheries can be heard. The varied responses in Sierra Leone, Mexico and Sri Lanka to a single European print show that these new versions are best understood not as copies that simply privilege the European print, but as responses, allowing us to locate them in a global dialogue with European prints. It is then

important to underline that the appreciation of ivory caskets as dialogic objects adds to, rather than detracts from, their importance to our understanding of premodern Sri Lankan visual culture. Hence, my project does not deny the European-ness of sixteenth-century Sri Lankan ivory caskets in comparison with earlier scholarship: it acknowledges it, and at the same time places the local visual world on an equal footing with the visual traditions of European prints from the Renaissance.